Introduction to Sociology

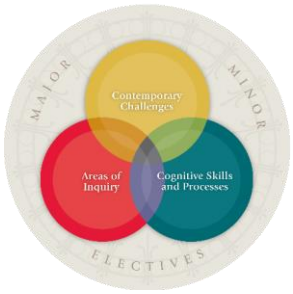
01:920:101:91

Fall 2024

Last updated 9/1/2024

Instructor

Dr. Morgan Ellis
mellis@rutgers.edu



Canvas Site

https://rutgers.instructure.com/courses/290704

This is an asynchronous online class. Lectures will be posted on Canvas, using PlayPosit, and all course materials will be accessible online. All participation and assignments will be due on Canvas. Reading schedule and due dates are indicated in the syllabus and may also be announced on Canvas.

Please make sure you are getting notifications for Announcements, as that will be the main way I communicate with the whole class.

Zoom Office Hours

Tuesdays 1:30 pm – 2:30 pm or by appointment
https://rutgers.zoom.us/j/XXXXXXX**XXX**XXXXXXX

You can contact me by email or through Canvas at any point during the semester. I will do my best to answer promptly but please allow 24-48 hours during weekdays for a response. I generally do not answer emails over the weekend. Do not wait until the last minute to send me important questions or information.

Course Description

The purpose of this course is to provide a basic understanding of sociology: its history, purpose, and main methodologies and practices. To accomplish this goal, we will be introduced to methods of sociological analysis to understand the social constructs and hierarchies of race, class, gender, and sexuality as well as important public issues, such as immigration, education, and health. We will look beyond individualistic explanations to the larger economic, social, political, and historical contexts that shape both individual and collective realities. These are what sociology aims to explain!

The goal of this class is not to memorize definitions and facts and regurgitate them onto a test, but rather to learn useful knowledge – knowledge that you can use to more fully understand the world around you and the social forces (many of which you may have never thought about) that shape your lives and the lives of the other 7 billion people with whom we share this planet. Together, we will cultivate critical thinking skills and learn how to apply our sociological imagination beyond the classroom.

Note: This syllabus is subject to change.

Learning Objectives

- Introduce students to basic sociological concepts, theories, and perspectives;
- Examine the relationship between the individual and society, as well as social "constraints" on individual agency;
- Develop an understanding of how culture, institutions, and group thought shape society and individuals;
- Apply sociological analysis to current events;
- Move beyond a narrow focus on our immediate relationships to a consideration of the role of larger social forces at both the local and global level.

Required Materials

- You do not need to purchase any reading materials for this class. All readings will be available through Canvas.
    - OPTIONAL: We will be reading some excerpts (provided by me) from chapters of *A Sociology Experiment*. The full textbook is available online here: https://sociologyexperiment.com/. You may create an account and purchase the complete chapters for $1 each if you wish to further your reading, but this is not required.

Summary of Assignments

Assignment	Due Date	% of Course Grade
Weekly lecture participation	Fridays at midnight	15%
Quiz #1	9/27/24	15%
Writing Assignment #1	10/13/24	20%
Quiz #2	11/1/24	15%
Writing Assignment #2	11/24/24	20%
Quiz #3	12/11/24	15%
Extra Credit (Optional)	Any time before 12/11/24	

Grading Scale

Please note that, once assigned, all grades are final.

Grade	Range
A	90-100
B+	86-89
B	80-85
C+	76-79
C	70-75
D	60-69
F	59 or Below

Assignments Overview

Lectures (15% of overall grade)

PlayPosit video lectures will be posted once a week on Canvas, at 8 am on Mondays, in that week's Module. These lectures will include embedded participation questions which must be completed by the end of the week (Fridays at midnight).

Weekly Readings

You are responsible for reading/watching all of the assigned materials (book chapters, articles, videos) each week. I encourage you to review these materials *before* the corresponding lecture. It will be obvious come exam time if you have not engaged with the material, therefore I greatly encourage you to actively engage with all the readings and take good notes while watching lectures. *ALL assigned readings and videos (including ones included in lectures) are fair game for exam questions!*

Three Quizzes (45% of overall grade; 15% for each quiz)

Rather than hold one midterm and one final exam, this course will include 3 scheduled online quizzes. Each quiz will consist of approximately 30 multiple-choice questions that pull from *both* the lectures *and* the assigned readings/videos. I will provide you with a study guide prior to the test date.
Once you log in and start a quiz during the scheduled date, you must complete the entire quiz in one sitting, within the time limit of one hour and 30 minutes (90 minutes total), unless you have an approved extension. You cannot stop the quiz to complete it later. Questions will appear one at a time. You have one opportunity/attempt to answer each question, not multiple attempts to change your answer. Once you answer a question, the following question will appear. Quizzes are open-note, but **collaboration during quizzes is not allowed** (although I encourage you to study beforehand with your classmates).

You are expected to complete quizzes at the date and time scheduled on the syllabus, therefore it is your responsibility to contact me if and when circumstances arise that prevent you from taking quizzes on the day they are available. *Make-ups for missed quizzes with no prior communication will be considered on a case-by-case basis and may be subject to a deduction of points or a "0" grade for that quiz.*

Two Written Reflections (40% of overall grade)

While the point of your quizzes is to test you on your knowledge and understanding, the writing assignments provide a chance for you to apply your ideas more creatively. Twice during the semester you will write a short reflection (approx. 600 words) in response to topics covered in the course. I will be grading you on your ability to follow instructions, identify and explain concrete concepts from class, and cite evidence to back up your claims.

The grading for each written assignment will be out of 10 points possible. Generally, I am looking for responses that:

- Fully address all aspects of the prompt(s);
- Make connections to course concepts in a concrete and detailed way;
- Demonstrate understanding of course concepts, and
- Cite sources to back up your claims (when applicable);
- Make connections between what you're reading and other examples from real life (current events, media or pop culture, your personal experiences, observations you've made);
- Use correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation as much as possible;
- Show civility and respect and demonstrate tolerance of diverse viewpoints.

Extra Credit: Field Notes Assignment

I will offer ONE opportunity for extra credit during the semester. You may complete this assignment at any point before the end of class. Instructions and a rubric will be provided separately. This assignment is OPTIONAL; you will not lose any points should you choose not to complete it.

Support and Policies

Late Work/Due Date Flexibility

Life happens, and last-minute things come up. The assignment deadlines are meant to guide you, not punish you. For this reason, all assignments have a ***12-hour grace period*** after the stated deadline during which you will not be penalized for turning work in late. If you know you will not be able to get your work in during this period, you should let me know in advance of the deadline so that we can arrange an extension. Extensions will be granted on a case-by-case basis for things such as illness or emergency.

Late submissions (turned in more than 12 hours after the stated deadline) without a granted extension will be subject to a deduction of 2 points off per day late, up to 10 points. Anything submitted more than 5 days past the stated deadline will receive zero points.

It will be up to each student to keep track of due dates throughout the course, as well as their own progress and grades. If you find that you are struggling with turning in assignments, understanding the course material, or maintaining a passing grade, please make an appointment to discuss with me as soon as possible. DO NOT wait until the last week of the term to express concerns about your grades.

Use of AI

The launch of AI assisted technologies is revolutionary. During this class we will spend time analyzing how such technologies have changed societies at large, including potential benefits and consequences. For this course, you may use AI tools such as ChatGPT or Gemini to help complete your written assignments if you wish. However: you should never turn in a paper with large swaths of text simply copied and pasted from an AI tool. This means that I expect you to engage with and edit any AI-produced text so that you are turning in a final product that is your own. Anything less will be treated as plagiarism and reported to Rutgers administration (see below section on Academic Integrity). If you have any questions about what exactly I will consider acceptable use of ChatGPT for these assignments, feel free to meet with me individually. I also suggest checking out this article for additional information on the pros and cons of AI in the classroom.

Please Note

We may experience interruptions this semester due to COVID-19 or other extenuating circumstances. Additionally, we are coming off of a very difficult few years of the pandemic, which has included increased isolation, loneliness, illness, and other struggles. If your mental or physical health are suffering, you are not alone. I will make a point to be flexible and understanding given these circumstances, and I encourage you to let me know if there is anything getting in the way of your academic performance.

Diversity and Inclusivity

The Rutgers Sociology Department strives to create an environment that supports and affirms diversity in all manifestations, including race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, religion, age, social class, disability status, region/country of origin, and political orientation. We also celebrate diversity of theoretical and methodological perspectives among our faculty and students and seek to create an atmosphere of respect and mutual dialogue. We have zero tolerance for violations of these principles and have clear and respectful procedures for responding to such grievances.

Additional Information

Academic Integrity

Honesty and Integrity are essential to the mission of the academy; as such, cheating of any kind will not be tolerated. Here is the link to Rutgers policy on academic integrity.

Plagiarism is the unacknowledged use of another person's work, including the use of copied and pasted AI-generated text (via apps like ChatGPT). Any cases of suspected plagiarism will be investigated and reported to the university administration – no exceptions. You are expected to be aware of all university guidelines on academic integrity as well as expectations specific to this class. If you have any questions about academic integrity policies, you may set up a time to meet and discuss with me.

Sociology Department Resources

Undergraduate Director: Dr. Jeffrey Dowd: ug-dir@sociology.rutgers.edu
Undergraduate Administrative Assistant: Carissa Nadonley: undergrad-soc@sociology.rutgers.edu

Learning Resources

Learning Centers: https://rlc.rutgers.edu/
Academic Advising for SAS students: https://sasundergrad.rutgers.edu/advising/advising
Online Learning Tools from Rutgers University Libraries including Rutgers RIOT, Searchpath and RefWorks: http://www.libraries.rutgers.edu/tutorials

Current Academic Integrity Policy

Summary: http://nbacademicintegrity.rutgers.edu/home-2/academic-integrity-policy
Resources for Students: https://nbprovost.rutgers.edu/academic-integrity-students

Technology

Please visit the Rutgers Student Tech Guide page for resources available to all students. If you do not have the appropriate technology for financial reasons, please email Dean of Students deanofstudents@echo.rutgers.edu for assistance. If you are facing other financial hardships, please visit the Office of Financial Aid at https://financialaid.rutgers.edu/.

Disability Services

(848) 445-6800 / Lucy Stone Hall, Suite A145, Livingston Campus, 54 Joyce Kilmer Avenue, Piscataway, NJ 08854 / https://ods.rutgers.edu/

Rutgers University welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs. In order to receive consideration for reasonable accommodations, a student with a disability must contact the appropriate disability services office at the campus where you are officially enrolled, participate in an intake interview, and provide documentation: https://ods.rutgers.edu/students/documentation-guidelines . If the documentation supports your request for reasonable accommodations, your campus's disability services office will provide you with a Letter of Accommodations. Please share this letter with your instructors and

discuss the accommodations with them as early in your courses as possible. To begin this process, please complete the Registration form on the ODS web site at: https://ods.rutgers.edu/students/registration-form.

Students with disabilities requesting accommodations must follow the procedures outlined at https://ods.rutgers.edu/students/getting-registered.

Counseling, ADAP & Psychiatric Services (CAPS)
(848) 932-7884 / 17 Senior Street, New Brunswick, NJ 08901 http://health.rutgers.edu/medical-counseling-services/counseling/

CAPS is a University mental health support service that includes counseling, alcohol and other drug assistance, and psychiatric services staffed by a team of professionals within Rutgers Health services to support students' efforts to succeed at Rutgers University. CAPS offers a variety of services that include: individual therapy, group therapy and workshops, crisis intervention, referral to specialists in the community, and consultation and collaboration with campus partners.

Crisis Intervention: http://health.rutgers.edu/medical-counseling- services/counseling/crisis-intervention/
Report a Concern: http://health.rutgers.edu/do-something-to-help/

Violence Prevention & Victim Assistance (VPVA)
(848) 932-1181 / 3 Bartlett Street, New Brunswick, NJ 08901 www.vpva.rutgers.edu/

The Office for Violence Prevention and Victim Assistance provides confidential crisis intervention, counseling and advocacy for victims of sexual and relationship violence and stalking to students, staff and faculty. To reach staff during office hours when the university is open or to reach an advocate after hours, call 848-932-1181.

Course Schedule

Week	Topic	Readings Due
Week 1 Sept 3	Introduction to the Course/What is Sociology?	Read through course syllabus
Week 2 Sept 9	Sociological Imagination	1. Excerpt from *A Sociology Experiment* (Khan, Sharkey, and Sharp) pp. 1-6 2. Excerpt from *Invitation to Sociology* (Berger)
	Social Psychology	1. Excerpt from *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (Goffman)
Week 3 Sept 16	Theory	1. Excerpt from *A Sociology Experiment* (Khan, Sharkey, and Sharp) pp.7-20 2. Excerpt from *The Communist Manifesto* (Marx and Engels)
	Research Methods	1. Excerpt from *Damned Lies and Statistics* (Best) 2. "Trick or Treat Sadists – A Halloween Urban Legend"
Week 4 Sept 23	Culture	1. "Body Ritual Among the Nacirema" 2. Excerpt from *Talk of Love: How Culture Matters* (Swidler)
Sept 27	***Quiz #1***	***Available on Canvas on Friday, September 27, for 24 hours***
Week 5 Sept 30	Stratification and Class	1. Excerpt from chapter: "Social Class, Inequality, and Poverty" (Kaufman and Schoepflin) pp. 1-22 2. "The Fading American Dream"
	Sex, Gender & Sexuality	1. Excerpt from chapter: "Gender and Sexuality" (Barian, Schoepflin, and Brown) pp. 4-9 2. Excerpt from: *Sexing the Body* (Fausto-Sterling)
Week 6 Oct 7	Race & Ethnicity	1. Chapter: "Race and Ethnicity" (Ray, Sharkey, and Clair) 2. "White Privilege: Unpacking the Invisible Knapsack"
	Writing Assignment #1	***Due Sunday, October 13, at midnight***
Week 7 Oct 14	Systemic Inequalities	1. "Preventing campus sexual assault isn't just about sex. It's also about race." 2. Excerpt from "Racism without Racists" (Bonilla-Silva)
	Economics and Labor	1. Excerpt from chapter: "Economic Sociology" (Rojas) pp. 5-17 2. "How Subtle Class Cues Can Backfire on Your Resume"
Week 8 Oct 21	Knowledge & Technology	1. "Have Smartphones Destroyed a Generation?" 2. "Why the past 10 years of American life have been uniquely stupid"
	Crime & Deviance	1. Excerpt from "The Saints and the Roughnecks" 2. Excerpt from "Is Prison Necessary?"

Week 9 Oct 28	Prisons	"13th" (DuVernay) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=krfcq5pF8u8
	Quiz #2	***Available on Canvas on Friday, November 1, for 24 hours***
Week 10 Nov 4	Environment	1. Excerpt from chapter: "Environmental Sociology" (Fisher and Jorgenson) pp. 6-13 2. Watch: https://www.storyofstuff.org/movies/story-of-stuff/ Available in Spanish: https://www.storyofstuff.org/movies/la-historia-de-las-cosas-2/
	Climate Change	1. Excerpt from chapter: "Environmental Sociology" (Fisher and Jorgenson) pp. 21-31 2. "The Great Climate Migration" https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2020/07/23/magazine/climate-migration.html (pdf on Canvas, but preferable to read through the link for interactive elements. Rutgers Library provides free NYT subscriptions for all students)
Week 11 Nov 11	Education	1. Excerpt from chapter: "Sociology of Education" (Cucchiara) pp.12-18
	Educational Inequalities	1 "It Takes More than Grit: Reframing Asian American Academic Achievement" 2. "How School Suspensions Push Black Students Behind"
Week 12 Nov 18	Health	1. Excerpt from *Deviance and Medicalization: From Badness to Sickness* (Conrad and Schneider) 2. "Why America's Black Mothers and Babies Are in a Life-or-Death Crisis"
	Writing Assignment #2	***Due Sunday, November 24, at midnight***
Week 13 Nov 25	Immigration	1. "Alone and Exploited, Migrant Children Work Brutal Jobs Across the U.S." 2. "None of us deserve citizenship"
Week 14 Dec 2	Politics	1. Excerpt from chapter: "Political Sociology" (Rojas) pp. 9-24 2. "Political Polarization in the American Public"
	Globalization	TBD
Week 15 Dec 9	***Quiz #3***	***Available on Canvas on Wednesday, December 11, for 24 hours***